THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #003

WINSTON WEINBERG AND THE ASSOCIATE WHO COLD-EMAILED SAM ALTMAN

A first-year lawyer and his roommate tested GPT-3 on a hundred Reddit questions and emailed the results to OpenAI. Four years later Harvey is valued at $15.5 billion, and the roommates still share the flat.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Winston Weinberg, Co-founder and CEO
COMPANY	Harvey
FOUNDED	2022
HQ	San Francisco
SECTOR	Legal AI
STAGE	Private, late stage
FUNDING	$550m at a $15.5bn valuation (September 2026)
MODEL	Per-seat enterprise contracts with law firms and in-house teams

Hello again, and welcome to File #003. Thank you for staying with us.

Picture a first-year litigation associate at a big Los Angeles law firm. He has been handed a landlord-tenant case, an area of law he has never touched, and he is trying to get up to speed fast. At home, his roommate, who spends his days doing AI research, shows him a new tool called GPT-3.

That associate was Winston Weinberg. The roommate was Gabe Pereyra. And what happened next is the shortest route we know from "I wonder if this works" to a company valued at $15.5 billion.

In File #001 we met Sam Altman, the most powerful person in AI. This week we meet someone who emailed him. Weinberg wasn't a researcher, an engineer or a Silicon Valley insider. He didn't grow up in San Francisco and had no tech connections. What he had was a job, a roommate, and a hundred questions from Reddit. (All figures are in US dollars.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Winston Weinberg, CEO, and Gabe Pereyra, president, co-founders of Harvey.
- **What:** Harvey sells AI to lawyers: research, drafting, due diligence and "agents" that carry out multi-step legal work. Its customers are law firms and the legal teams inside big companies.
- **Why it matters:** it is the clearest example of a company built on top of someone else's model, by the person who understood the work. It also shows how fast a whole profession can reprice itself once it gets nervous about being late.
- **The number to remember:** 86. That is how many of 100 answers three lawyers said they'd send to a client, without editing, in the test that started it all. (More on how much weight that number can bear below.)

THE FOUNDERS

Weinberg's route to this point was not a straight line, and he is refreshingly honest about it. He has said that for most of his life he was a poor student who kept getting thrown out of schools, that he struggled with his mental health when he was younger, and that he hadn't found anything he wanted to get up for in the morning. He has also said that part of his intensity today comes from the memory of that stretch, and from a fear of drifting back into it. So he deliberately looks for discomfort: every week, he says, he tries to do a few things that make him properly uneasy.

He went on to study at Kenyon College and then at the University of Southern California's law school, graduating in 2021. He joined O'Melveny & Myers, a big Los Angeles firm, as a litigator working on securities and antitrust cases. It was the kind of first-year job that comes with long weeks and a great deal of routine work.

Pereyra came from the other side of the table. He studied computer science at USC, started a neuroscience PhD at Oxford that DeepMind paid for, and left it unfinished to work in AI research at Google, DeepMind and Meta. The two had met a couple of years earlier, reconnected, and ended up as roommates.

The pairing is the whole point. Pereyra could tell when a model was bluffing. Weinberg could tell when a lawyer wouldn't send the result. Neither of them could do the other's job, and that turned out to be the strength.

They are still roommates. When the New York Times profiled them, with the company valued at $8 billion, Weinberg was 30 and Pereyra 34, and the two were still sharing the same apartment, along with a third roommate. Asked about being billionaires, Weinberg said, "it's on paper". It's the right word. Nothing here has been sold.

THE PROBLEM

Legal work is, at its heart, reading and writing at scale: reading thousands of pages of contracts before a deal closes, drafting the same kinds of documents again and again, researching what a court has already said. Junior lawyers do much of it, and they are paid by the hour for the privilege. It is expensive, repetitive and unforgiving. A wrong answer in a legal document is not an awkward typo. It can cost a client millions.

That is also exactly why law firms had not embraced earlier AI tools. They have strict confidentiality duties, they are cautious by temperament, and they are very quick to say no. The problem Harvey set out to solve was therefore twofold: build something good enough to be trusted, and sell it to people whose entire profession is built around not trusting things.

THE PRODUCT

The idea started with a test. Pereyra showed Weinberg GPT-3 at the end of 2021. They didn't write a pitch deck. They wrote a careful prompt around California landlord-tenant law, took 100 real questions from Reddit's r/legaladvice forum, and had the model answer them. Then they hid who had written the answers and asked three landlord-tenant lawyers to review them. According to Weinberg, for 86 of the 100 questions the lawyers said the answer was good enough to send to a client without changes.

It's worth being clear about what that does and doesn't prove. The test was small, and the scoring has never been published. It is not evidence that a model is 86 percent accurate at law. It is evidence that practising lawyers, looking blind, might treat the output as usable. That is a different and more commercial fact, and it was enough.

They emailed the results to Sam Altman and to Jason Kwon, then OpenAI's general counsel. On the morning of 4 July 2022 they pitched OpenAI's leadership, and the backing followed. In November, Harvey came out of hiding with a $5 million seed round led by the OpenAI Startup Fund. They had no customers yet. The first institutional money came from the lab whose model they were building on.

The name is a small piece of strategy. It is a human name, so a lawyer can think of the tool as a colleague. It nods to Harvey Specter, the lawyer in the TV drama *Suits* who made a generation want the job. This year Harvey even signed a brand deal with Gabriel Macht, the actor who played him, and launched an Instagram account under the handle @askharvey. For a buyer as cautious as a law firm, a friendly brand is part of the product.

The believer with letterhead. Harvey needed one big firm to take a risk. Allen & Overy, now A&O Shearman, had been testing Harvey since November 2022. In February 2023 it announced a rollout to its lawyers across 43 offices, after about 3,500 of them had put around 40,000 questions to it during the trial. By the time Sequoia led a $21 million Series A that April, more than 15,000 law firms were reportedly on a waiting list.

That is the distribution lesson. Legal AI doesn't spread through an app store. It spreads through one firm that is willing to look bold, then through every other firm that is afraid of looking late.

From chatbot to workspace. Early on, the founders sent thousands of LinkedIn messages to get anyone to look at the product, and early access to GPT-4 transformed what they could build. Today Harvey is a workspace for research, drafting and analysis, with a secure vault for a firm's own documents and tools that let teams build their own workflows. By March 2026 customers had built more than 25,000 custom agents on it. In June 2025 a deal with LexisNexis put US case law, statutes and its Shepard's citation checks inside Harvey. That matters, because a model that invents a case isn't a drafting assistant. It's a malpractice risk.

The twist. In August 2026 Harvey launched its first model of its own, called Tenet. It isn't built from scratch. Harvey took an open-weight model, Kimi K3 from the Chinese lab Moonshot AI, and trained it further on long, multi-step legal work with a partner, Fireworks AI. Harvey says Tenet completes almost twice as many of its test tasks as the base model at roughly the same cost. The company also published a new open benchmark, Harvey LAB, of more than 1,200 legal tasks across 24 practice areas, so that it can show its working. Harvey says the motive is cost and quality: cheaper tokens, and a model tuned for the work.

Weinberg has been upfront about the strategic risk. Harvey was founded on the assumption that the model makers would one day become competitors, so the real product has to be what sits around the model: the firm's documents, the workflow, and the audit trail.

THE FUNDING

The round history is a chart of how fast a market can reprice when its buyers get nervous.

- **November 2022:** $5 million seed, led by the OpenAI Startup Fund, with Elad Gil, Sarah Guo and Jeff Dean.
- **April 2023:** $21 million Series A, led by Sequoia.
- **December 2023:** $80 million Series B at a $715 million valuation, led by Elad Gil and Kleiner Perkins.
- **July 2024:** $100 million Series C at $1.5 billion, led by GV.
- **February 2025:** $300 million at $3 billion, led by Sequoia.
- **June 2025:** $300 million at $5 billion, led by Kleiner Perkins and Coatue.
- **December 2025:** $160 million at $8 billion, led by Andreessen Horowitz.
- **March 2026:** $200 million at $11 billion, co-led by GIC and Sequoia.
- **9 September 2026:** $550 million at $15.5 billion, co-led by Lightspeed and Diffusion, with Sapphire Ventures and Whale Rock joining Sequoia, Kleiner Perkins, Andreessen Horowitz, Coatue, GIC and others. Some outlets, citing Bloomberg, put the valuation at $15.6 billion.

Put differently, the valuation grew about 41 percent in six months, and Harvey has now raised more than $1.5 billion in total. On the same day it announced the round, Harvey bought Guardrails AI, a San Francisco company that builds safety controls for AI agents. It was Harvey's fourth acquisition this year.

THE BUSINESS MODEL

Harvey sells mostly through per-seat contracts with law firms, in-house legal teams and a smaller number of asset managers, with custom work for some big clients. The company doesn't publish its prices. Outside estimates put a seat at about $1,000 a month at some firms and a good deal less for very large deals, with minimum seat counts. Treat those as rumours, not facts.

Here is what has been confirmed or widely reported:

- Annual recurring revenue passed $100 million in August 2025, about three years after founding, and ended the year at around $190 million.
- This September it was reported to be above $400 million. That figure is widely repeated but wasn't in Harvey's funding announcement, so treat it as the company's number, not a verified one.
- Harvey says 80 percent of the Am Law 100, the biggest US law firms, now use it, along with five Fortune 10 companies. Customer counts have also grown, from about 1,300 in March to a reported 3,000 or more by September. For context, an independent report in April 2025 had Harvey in 28 percent of the Am Law 100. Growth like that is very fast, and it comes from the company itself.
- The mix is shifting. At the start of 2025 about 96 percent of the business was law firms and 4 percent corporate legal teams. By late 2025 corporate teams were about a third.

At $400 million of revenue, $15.5 billion is roughly 39 times sales. That is a growth multiple, not an earnings multiple. Investors pay it when they believe the workflow could become the system of record for professional services, not just law. Harvey is already talking about tax and finance.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

The model still makes things up. Stanford's RegLab tested the leading AI legal research tools in 2024-era versions and found they gave wrong or misleading answers between about 17 and 34 percent of the time, better than a general chatbot but nowhere near safe to trust blindly. Courts have kept pace: a public database of cases involving AI-fabricated citations passed 2,000 by September. Harvey's answer is sourcing, the Lexis partnership and a lawyer who still signs off. That helps, but the risk never fully goes away, and a single bad case in a famous firm would sting.

Everyone wants this market. Legora, a Stockholm company, raised $550 million at a $5.5 billion valuation in March. Thomson Reuters has CoCounsel built into Westlaw, and Clio

has bought the legal-research company vLex. Even Harvey's own partner, LexisNexis, is also a rival. And there is the question Weinberg raised himself: what happens if the labs ship a good enough legal agent?

The billable hour. If a first-pass contract summary takes minutes, a bill for six hours of associate time is harder to defend. Law firms are Harvey's customers, and they make their money from the very thing Harvey makes faster. Weinberg has said he cares about this, and that AI should help junior lawyers learn faster, not vanish. But if the work that used to train juniors goes to machines, the next generation of partners has to come from somewhere.

The price tag. Thirty-nine times revenue assumes the growth continues, and the 80 percent figure comes from the company. Earning the valuation every day is the right goal. It is also what founders tend to say when the number has gotten a little ahead of the proof.

The supply chain. Harvey's new model starts from a Chinese lab's open-weight base. That is a legitimate and increasingly common technique, and the model is a research preview. But a profession built on confidentiality and caution is likely to ask where the model came from and what it was trained on.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **The 80 percent.** Does Harvey keep winning inside the Am Law 100, and does it spread to firms outside the top tier, where the price per seat is harder to justify?
2. **Tenet.** Does Harvey's own model make it cheaper and better, or does it prompt clients to ask harder questions about its origins?
3. **The labs.** Do OpenAI, Anthropic or Google ship a legal agent that is good enough, and does Harvey's workflow, its vault and its audit trail hold up as the moat?
4. **The incumbents.** Do Thomson Reuters, LexisNexis and Clio decide the partnership era is over?
5. **The billable hour.** Do firms and their clients start to renegotiate how legal work is priced, and who wins when they do?

He was a junior associate. The company he built is now inside most of the firms that used to hire him. It's a story about a job, and what happens when the person doing it leaves to build the thing that changes it.

That's File #003. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #004 lands next Sunday.

Facts in this file are drawn from the sources below. Where a figure is reported rather than confirmed by the company, we say so. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

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